the group CEO of Tata Motors and Speth as the CEO of Jaguar and Land Rover.

Ratan himself was on overdrive, assuming multiple roles. ‘His technical understanding is amazing. He could raise the right question that even those persons leading the projects could not,’ Arun Gandhi recalls. He spent considerable time on JLR’s shop floor, advising and monitoring work, Gandhi adds. ‘We have not had anyone like [Ratan Tata who] gets into the nitty-gritty.’

‘The [Land Rover] cars improved drastically’ and Ratan gave several inputs for the design changes, even regarding the colour of the upholstery in the cars to the kind of handles they should have. Ironically, a company that was ridiculed for its supposed ignorance of luxury trends had contributed to the dramatic turnaround of the marquees. The ‘Land Rovers had the highest sales’ after the Tatas took over and the ‘future of the company is brighter than at any point of time before’, Weidinger says. Gerry McGovern, director, Land Rover Design, once wrote to Ratan, ‘It’s not often [that] you meet someone who has the depth of understanding for these disciplines that you clearly have!’

Ratan was hands-on with the Jaguar as well. Coordinating with Ian Callum, the Jaguar’s design director, he personally reviewed the modifications in the Jaguar E-Type and F-Type, emphasizing on changes that ‘might enhance the reminiscence’ of the earlier designs. He also played a significant role in developing the themes for the Jaguar X12 range. Ratan was involved in the opening of some showrooms and corresponding with important dealers as well.

By 2010, the decision to acquire Jaguar Land Rover stood vindicated. ‘With the positive market reception of the enhanced product range in an improved market environment’, Jaguar Land Rover ‘turned profitable for the year [ending] March 31, 2010, reporting a Profit before Tax of GBP 32 million’.

In his address to the shareholders in July 2010, Ratan said that the ‘Jaguar/Land Rover wholesale sales for FY 2009–10’ had grown to ‘almost 194,000 units’ with both the brands improving their ‘performance impressively mainly due to the very positive customer response to its newly-launched luxury sedans and the fact that the Company [had] succeeded in achieving a significant reduction in cost with improved operational efficiencies’.